

"Protecting tigers is a tough job. We have to keep at it."

Minister of Environment and Forests Jairam Ramesh spoke with MIHIR SRIVASTAVA about the precarious situation of the tiger reserves, dwindling tiger population and ongoing efforts to save them. Excerpts from the interview:

Q. How do you plan to save the tiger in India?

A. It is a long-drawn process with no overnight solutions. It would need a lot of efforts to reverse the trends. We would have to deal with the real estate mafia, mining mafia and criminal mafia linked to the international smuggling of tiger parts. These issues need to be recognised and addressed.

Q. Is the Government still to recognise these issues?

A. We have recognised these issues. We have entered into a

tripartite agreement with the state governments and the park managements in all the 39 tiger reserves to help define roles and responsibilities.

Q. But tigers and people cannot live together. People know killing a tiger means big money.

A. The core areas are inviolate and exclusive for tigers; buffer zone is an inclusive zone. Relocation of some 80,000 families out of forests, both in the core and buffer zones, are being given importance. Each family is being paid Rs 10 lakh. We have so far moved 3,000 families out of the forests but the process needs to be expedited.

Q. Are you also open to private participation in the conservation

of forests?

A. No. We have created a Tiger Conservation Foundation for every tiger reserve. They can contribute money to help the cause.

Q. There is no accountability mechanism in place. How do you plan to deal with it?

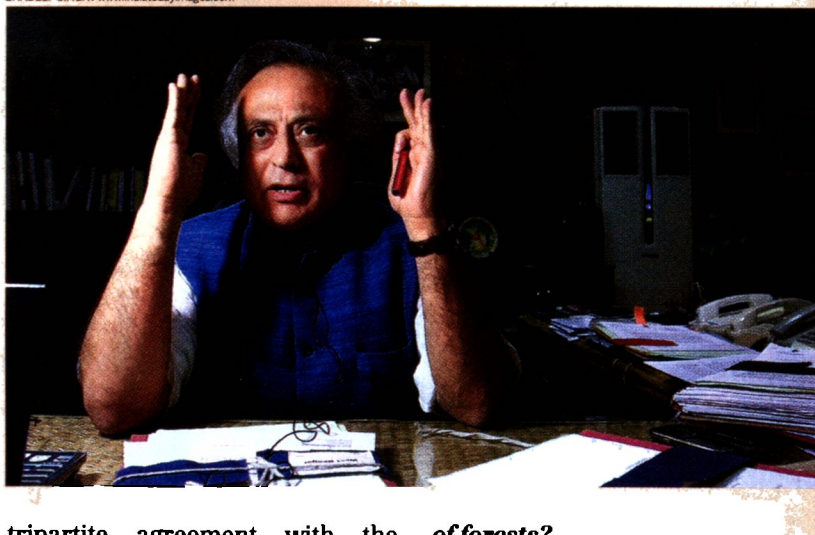
A. The tripartite agreement will help in better information exchange and coordination. Protecting tigers is a tough job. We have to keep at it.

peers are travelling and on what mission. He explains the economics of poaching. The Rs 2 lakh for each tiger killed is shared between the team members, but according to the size of their families. The sharing of booty leads to conflicts too, as the spat between the Dabuliya Bai and the Kanthi Lal gangs reveal.

Critics of the scheme abound, and claim that the scheme merely allows poachers to go hunting more freely, unencumbered by children. However, Pramod Shukla, a forest guard involved in this project, insists that there are advantages. "Thanks to this project, we



TIGER SKIN ON DISPLAY AT A SHOP IN LHASA



now have access to the Pardhis. They have opened up before us. We understand them better and we have been able to breach their earlier impregnable fortress and this can be used for counter-poaching operations as well as to reform them." But reforming the Pardhis seems to be a far cry given the scenario seen by INDIA TODAY. For forest officials, the emphasis is on protection of tigers within protected areas. But when the big cats move out to territorial forests, they are easy prey for the poachers and their steel traps.

Acknowledges Sanjoy Majumdar, conservator of forests in Katni: "A forest guard with 10 sq km to cover on foot can do little against poaching." He points to many cases where it is difficult to save a forest guard if he happens to kill a poacher in the forest, as the guard will then be tried for the murder. Invariably, the forest guard in such cases has had to be suspended pending the inquiry.

The Pardhis travel to far-flung places

tripartite agreement with the state governments and the park managements in all the 39 tiger reserves to help define roles and responsibilities.

Q. How are the 39 tiger reserves doing?

A. Nine of them are in good condition, 14 are satisfactory and 16 in poor state.

Q. How do you plan to deal with it?

A. We need to give local commu-